Hero Stones

Hero stones are memorials erected for those who lost their lives in the battles and in cattle raids. As cattle were considered an important source of wealth, raiding cattle owned by adjoining tribes and clans was common practice in a pastoral society. During the Sangam Age, the *Mullai* landscape followed the pastoral way of life. Tribal chieftains plundered the cattle wealth of enemies whose warriors fought to protect their cattle. Many warriors died in such battles and were remembered as martyrs. Memorial stones were erected in their honour. Sangam literature vividly portrays these battles and clashes, and describes such hero stones as objects of worship. *Tholkappiyam* describes the procedures for erecting hero stones.

Hero stones of the Sangam Age with Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions can be found at Pulimankombai and Thathapatti in Theni district and Porpanaikottai in Pudukkottai district. Those of the Sangam Age discovered till now do not have images or sculptures.

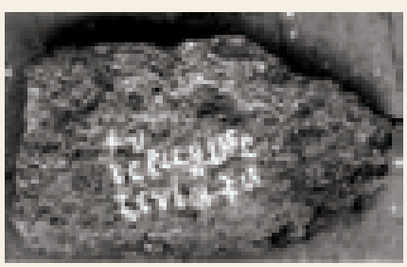
Pulimankombai Hero stone

Pulimankombai is a village in the Vaigai river valley in Theni district. In 2006, rare hero stone inscriptions in Tamil-Brahmi script were discovered in this village.

One of the inscriptions from Pulimankombai reads

"Kudalur Akol pedu tiyan antavan kal"

It means "The stone of Tiyan Antavan who was killed in a cattle raid at the village of Kudalur".



Hero stone-Pulimankombai

Hero stones of the post-Sangam Age and the Pallava period occur in large numbers in pastoral regions especially around the Chengam region near Thiruvannamalai district. These hero stones have inscriptions and the images of warriors and names of heroes.

Inscriptions on Pottery

Pottery vessels from the Early Historic Period have names of people engraved on them in Tamil-Brahmi script. Potsherds have been discovered in Arikkamedu, Azhagankulam, Kodumanal, Keezhadi, and many other sites in Tamil Nadu. Pottery inscribed with names in Tamil-Brahmi script have also been found in Berenike and Quseir al Qadhim in Egypt and in Khor Rori in Oman indicating that early Tamils had trade contacts with West Asia and along the Red Sea coast. People etched their names on pottery to indicate ownership. Many of the names are in Tamil while some are in **Prakrit**.



A motif of a ship on pottery from Azhagankulam

Prakrit was the language used by the common people in the Northern part of India during the Mauryan period.

Archaeological Sites

Archaeological excavation refers to systematically digging a site to recover material evidence for exploring and interpreting societies of the past.

Archaeological excavations at the early historic sites are the source of evidence of the activities of the Sangam Age people. Excavations at Arikkamedu, Azhagankulam, Uraiyur, Kanchipuram, Kaveripoompattinam, Korkai,